This is delicious in the fall, when it will use up any particularly mature cucumbers, although you may need to remove any hard seeds and bitter skin.

cucumber and walnut soup

SERVES 4–6 **PREP** 10–15 MINS PLUS 30 MINS CHILLING **FREEZE** NOT SUITABLE

CHILLED

2 medium cucumbers, about 1lb 9oz (700g) in total
1lb 2oz (500g) Greek or thick and creamy yogurt
1 clove garlic
coarse sea salt
1¾oz (50g) walnuts, plus more chopped walnuts for garnish
handful of fresh mint leaves, finely chopped
2 tbsp fresh lemon juice
freshly ground black pepper
extra virgin olive oil, to serve

1 Peel, seed, and finely dice the cucumbers. Be diligent about this to ensure your soup is delicately flavored without any bitterness.

2 In a medium bowl or large measuring jug, mix together the yogurt and 1 cup cold water until combined. Pound the garlic with a large pinch of coarse sea salt in a mortar until smooth. Scrape it into the yogurt. Pound the walnuts in the garlicky mortar to a coarse paste; do not crush them too fine. Add to the yogurt mixture with the cucumber, mint, lemon juice, and a good grinding of pepper and stir well. Taste and adjust the seasoning.

3 Cover and chill for 30 minutes or more. Pour into bowls and garnish with a drizzle of olive oil and a few chopped walnuts.



CUCUMBERS
Go for locally grown cucumbers that feel firm and avoid any with soggy, limp ends. Be sure to store them in the refrigerator for no longer than a week, as they contain mostly water and will quickly lose their vibrancy.